

Lesson 4: The Glass Cubicle: Gender Microaggressions

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"You're very articulate for a woman."

"You don't look like an engineer."

"Who babysits your kids while you're at work?"

"I didn't expect you to be so assertive!"

"You're the office mom."

"Why aren't you smiling?"

Any of these sound familiar?

Chances are if you're a woman that you've heard your fair share of these over the years!

A microaggression is an everyday verbal or behavioral action that communicates subtle, negative, messages toward an individual or group.

These are different than macroaggressions, which is discrimination on a much larger scale.

This is important, because we often tend to measure the progress towards gender equality with the progress in the lane of macroaggressions or large-scale discrimination without realizing and addressing the everyday wear and tear microaggressions take on women in leadership.

Microaggressions aren't exclusive to women – men get them too.

"Real men don't cry."

"You should know how to fix this."

"You know men aren't good at multitasking."

"You're really sensitive for a guy."

"You like to cook? Don't tell anyone!"

Did some of these irritate you? The truth is...*no one likes microaggressions!*

There are three types of microaggressions – verbal, non-verbal, and institutional.

We've covered some examples of *verbal*. *Non-verbal* might be something like, looking for approval from one gender in a business meeting while ignoring the other gender, or paying attention when men are speaking but goofing off while a woman is presenting in a conference.

Again, it goes both ways!

And this is important, because the daily battle for equality in the workplace is often won or lost in the area of microaggressions and how prevalent they are in your own workplace culture.

The first step is being aware of what microaggressions are and how to spot them at work. You want to make sure both men and women are aware of what microaggressions are, and how not to perpetuate unfair stereotypes with everyday comments or behavior.

In the upcoming lesson, we'll discuss more of how to handle microaggressions and steps you can take to eliminating them in your workplace.